down when Margot Feist fell pregnant, and later gave birth to a 6½ lb baby daughter, Sonja. Some weeks later, with Honecker's parents Wilhelm and Karolina in attendance, Sonja was christened at a name-giving ceremony in Pankow.

Soon after, Margot and Erich married. However, Margot was then packed-off on a one-year course to the Soviet Union, leaving Sonja in the care of her parents. Speaking in 1990, Margot lamented this 'almost inhuman' decision and blamed Ulbricht for what she saw as some kind of perverted punishment for past indiscretions.

Characteristically, while Margot was away, Erich – as one associate delicately put it – did not lack female attention. Markus Wolf, a member of the state security services, recounted how Honecker remained discreet, but on one occasion was spotted 'surreptitiously slipping' through the backstreets of East Berlin. Left in no doubt that he was visiting a secret girlfriend, Wolf informed his superior, who reacted with no surprise but insisted on filing details of the indiscretion.

On the work front, Honecker began to restore his reputation as a fearsome supporter of the SED's tightening political course. A year earlier, he had backed the first five-year plan which pushed a more assertive agenda to increase production, especially in the industrial sector.6 He cheered loudly at the Second Party Conference in July 1952 when Ulbricht promised to codify his socialist ambitions by expanding heavy industry at the expense of consumer goods. Over the summer, the plan was put into practice as the SED set to work forming agricultural cooperatives based on state-controlled Soviet collectives.

However, amid the 'propaganda' success of the scheme, the reality was a disaster, as the forced collectivisation of agriculture proved one of the greatest traumas Germany had experienced since 1945. The pattern was familiar to Soviet historians, who watched in horror as chaos erupted on farms, sparking food riots and industrial unrest. By November, the GDR government was scraping the bottom of the food barrel to tide itself over.

In a tactic to deflect blame, Otto Grotewohl attributed the crisis to 'Western speculators, imperialist hate propaganda, the weather, saboteurs, failings in